

The Treaty of London in 1864 resulted in the United Kingdom ceding the United States of the Ionian Islands to Greece. Britain had held an amical protectorate over the islands since the 1815 Treaty of Paris.

The federated United States of the Ionian Islands included seven islands off the coasts of Epirus and the Peloponnese, that had remained in Venetian hands until 1797 and escaped Ottoman rule. Of the seven, six lay in the Ionian Sea, off the western coast of the Greek mainland. These six states were Corfù (Kerkyra), Ithaca(Ithaki), Paxò(paxoi/paxos), Cephalonia, Zante (Zakynthos) and Santa Maura (Lefkas). Cerigo (Kythera) was also a state of the federation, although it is situated southeast of the Peloponnese.

Ever since the Greek War of Independence against the Ottoman Empire, the people of the Ionian Islands had pressed for union, or enosis, with Greece. At a meeting of the British Cabinet in 1862, Foreign Secretary Henry John Temple, 3rd Viscount Palmerston decided to cede the islands to Greece. This policy was also favoured by Queen Victoria.

The decision to cede the islands was also influenced by the accession to the Greek throne of the Danish prince George, a committed Anglophile. Indeed, in a referendum in November 1862, the Greeks had elected Queen Victoria's second son, Prince Alfred, as their king, partly in the hope of receiving the Ionian Islands.

After long negotiations with Greece, the Treaty of London was signed by Greek delegate Charilaos Trikoupis on 29 March 1864. On 21 May 1864 the British departed and the Ionian Islands became three provinces of the Kingdom of Greece, although Britain retained use of the port on Corfu.

This can be seen as the first example of voluntary decolonization by Britain. For Greece, the incorporation of the Ionian Islands was the first of several territorial increases to 1947.

Terms of the Treaty

Demolition of the fortifications of Corfu.

Preservation of the rights of the United Kingdom to the use of the port of Corfu.

Transfer to the Greek State of public debts, commercial contracts and compensations to British individuals and legal entities.

Maps

See also

Treaties of London

Further reading

Anderson M. S. *The Eastern Question 1774–1923, A Study in the International Relations* (London, 1983).

Paschalidi, Maria. "Constructing Ionian identities: the Ionian Islands in British official discourses; 1815-1864" (PhD dissertation. UCL (University College London), 2010) online.

Temperley, H. Documents Illustrating the Cession of the Ionian Islands to Greece, 1848-70, *The Journal of Modern History*, IX/1, Chicago 1937, pp. 48–55.

Xenos, Stephanos Th. *East and West: A Diplomatic History of the Annexation of the Ionian Islands to the Kingdom of Greece* (Trübner, 1865) online.

External links

Details of the 1864 Treaty of London